

CIC for publishing paper-wise UPSC marks of candidates

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Central Information Commission (CIC) has recommended reinstating the practice of publishing the detailed break-up of marks obtained by selected candidates in the Civil Services (Main) Examination after finding that the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) had no record of any formal decision behind discontinuing the practice from 2018.

The recommendation came amid contradictory positions of the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) and DoPT on custody of the detailed marks.

While the UPSC told the commission that after declaration of the final result it gives the detailed break-up of marks to the DoPT and the Lal Bahadur Shastri National Academy of Administration (LBSNAA), the DoPT maintained that the detailed marks are generated and maintained solely by the UPSC.

The matter arose from an RTI application seeking comparative data of marks obtained by all selected candidates in each General Studies paper, optional subject paper and the Per-

The order came amid contradictory positions of the UPSC and DoPT on custody of detailed marks

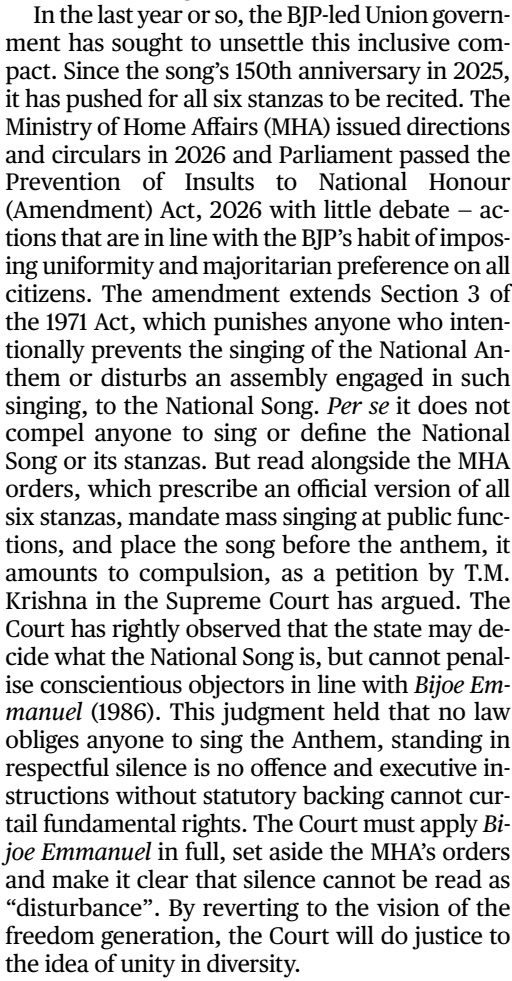
sonality Test over 10 years, up to 2023. The applicant also sought information on how different optional subjects had fared in terms of marks. The applicant contended that while paper-wise marks of recommended candidates were publicly disclosed until CSE 2017, only aggregate marks were being made available from 2018 onwards, affecting aspirants' ability to assess performance trends in different optional subjects.

'No file noting'

The CIC noted that despite being given a final opportunity, the DoPT failed to produce any file noting, office memorandum, policy decision or other record substantiating the discontinuation of publication of the marks from 2018 onwards.

The commission observed that the detailed marks "should be disclosed" to ensure "transparency and fairness in the selection procedure".





On October 16, 1994, T.N. Seshan, then Chief Election Commissioner of India, issued an order under the Election Symbols (Reservation and Allotment) Order, 1968, in which he highlighted the “ad hocism” and the “sorry state of affairs prevailing in almost all political parties in the country, whether recognised National or State parties or registered-unrecognised parties”. He observed, “I have yet to come across any party whose affairs are being run in accordance with the provisions of its constitution or rules and regulations.” Through the order, T.N. Seshan put all political parties on “notice” to set their house in order, declaring that the ECI would not remain a “mute spectator”. In subsequent guidelines prescribing the format for registration under Section 29A of the Representation of the People Act (RPA), 1951, the ECI stated in paragraph 3(xxiii) that a party seeking registration must declare in its constitution that it will contest elections within five years of registration and that, if it does not “contest elections continuously



The study found that, over the last decade, the exchequer 'lost' ₹11,813 crore in taxes due to exemptions for political donations, with individual donors and Hindu Undivided Families overtaking corporates in donating to political parties. In FY2022-23, individual donors claimed exemptions worth ₹2,275.85 crore, dwarfing corporate claims of ₹514.4 crore and those of firms and associations, at ₹15.71 crore. Declared donations to political parties increased from ₹714 crore (43 parties) in 2015-16 to ₹7,203 crore (27 parties) in 2023-24. Yet, only 41.76% of total donations, amounting to ₹28,287 crore over nine years, were claimed as tax-exempt, raising questions about the remaining 58%. Mr. Nayak asks: "What incentives are driving them to donate without tax relief? The lack of transparency obscures answers."

Let the ECI spend its energy and authority on ‘purifying’ the electoral environment rather than on chasing genuine electors off the electoral rolls. Until then, ‘We the People’ must continue to scream “*Hami yaha chhau* (we are here)”.

One question before any photograph goes out could be a beginning: is the disclosure necessary to the investigation, or merely convenient to the narrative?

Should permanent membership, veto powers of the UNSC be abolished?



Amitabh Mattoo

Dean of School of International Studies, JNU



Swaran Singh

Former Professor of the School of International Studies, JNU

PARLEY

In the ongoing session of the UN General Assembly (UNGA), France has made a proposal to enhance the functioning of the UN, especially in dealing with collective security and the use of veto. France has been advocating that the use of veto in the UN Security Council (UNSC) be “regulated” when it comes to dealing with humanitarian crises such as in Sudan, Lebanon or in cases of genocide. France believes that the use of veto is not a matter of “privilege” but of “responsibility”. So, should permanent membership and veto powers of the UN Security Council be abolished? Amitabh Mattoo and Swaran Singh discuss the question in a conversation moderated by Kallol Bhattacharjee. Edited excerpts:

Is it realistically possible to imagine an UNSC where veto would be “regulated” as the French proposal suggested?

Amitabh Mattoo: What Emmanuel Macron (President of France) articulated in the UNGA on September 22 is not entirely new. What we are seeing is really a renewed push behind what used to be called the French-Mexican initiative, first launched in 2015, under which permanent members of the SC would voluntarily refrain from using the veto in situations involving genocide, crimes against humanity, and large-scale war crimes. It’s not an attempt to abolish the veto or amend the UN charter. It’s essentially an exercise in self-restraint by the P5 (permanent members of the UNSC: U.S., U.K., France, China and Russia). What gives the initiative fresh significance is not just Mr. Macron’s speech, but the political momentum behind it. France and Mexico both announced this week that 128 states now support the declaration, with 21 joining in the last four months. And the significant part is that the U.K., another P5 country, has now joined France in accepting the principle.

So for the first time, two of the five permanent members have committed themselves to this form of voluntary restraint.

But I think we should also distinguish between three different questions which are often conflated – the use of the veto, accountability for the use of the veto, and the much larger question of reform of the Security Council. Mr. Macron’s initiative addresses only the first. It says in effect, even if the veto remains, surely there must be circumstances of exceptional human suffering in which a permanent member agrees not to exercise it. It is, as I said, a modest incremental proposition institutionally, but potentially significant



A general view of the UNGA in New York City, U.S., on September 22. REUTERS

normatively in terms of what we want the world to be like. It seeks to change the political behaviour of the five permanent countries without undertaking what seems to be the almost impossible task of rewriting the charter. So, it’s a modest proposal and it has got some momentum, but whether it translates into reality, we’ll have to wait and see.

Does the current situation in UNGA indicate that the P5 is now divided between the France-U.K. and Russia-U.S.-China factions on the use of veto?

Swaran Singh: Clearly, the U.K. and France are not the heavyweights among the P5. Therefore, I think it is easier for France and the U.K. to make that principled position saying that the P5, which wield veto power, should be able to better regulate or manage how fundamentally the power is utilised; to make sure that the UNSC is able to take action and that it does not get paralysed. In fact, the contradiction of 2013 itself was driven by the fact that in the civil war in Syria, Chinese and Russian vetoes were making it impossible for the UNSC to pass any resolution condemning Syria. After the August 2013 chemical weapons attack in Ghouta in September, the then French President Francois Hollande had in his speech proposed a ‘code of good conduct’ for the UNSC. This is where, for the first time, a kind of proposition was made that the P5 could voluntarily restrain the use of veto in cases of genocide, crimes against humanity or larger war crimes. I think the attempt was to skirt amending the UN Charter and still make it much more contemporaneous. None of the P5 are talking of eliminating veto power that they have. There are multiple versions among the five as to how they wish to reform the UN Security Council.

As an ideal, we believe that we live in a world



As an ideal, we believe that we live in a world of sovereign equality, but in reality, because of the way power is distributed, it is impossible for any international organisation to survive – not just become effective – but even survive if they happen to take a decision against any of the major powers

SWARAN SINGH

of sovereign equality, but in reality, because of the way power is distributed, it is impossible for any international organisation to survive – not just become effective – but even survive if they happen to take a decision against any of the major powers. Incidentally, veto is not a word mentioned in the UN Charter and it was created through a separate mechanism. But the premise is that any international organisation must not take a decision against the fundamental interests of any major power if they wish to survive.

While doubts persist about the veto, the question is will veto continue to be extended to new members of the UNSC whenever they are inducted?

AM: Apart from Mr. Macron’s or the France-Mexican initiative, there have been incremental reforms which fall short of trying to amend the UN Charter. There was an earlier Liechtenstein initiative, which was adopted by the UNGA in 2022, which took a different route. It did not prevent a permanent member from exercising the veto. Instead, whenever a veto was cast, the General Assembly would be convened within 10 working days to debate the issue. In other words, a veto will no longer be allowed to simply terminate the conversation. The permanent member concerned would have to explain and defend its action on the floor of the UNGA. That was one initiative which was passed by the UNGA. A third initiative, also similar to the French-Mexican initiative, is the ‘ACT code of conduct’ or the Accountability, Coherence and Transparency Initiative. This goes beyond the P5 and asks members of the Security Council, including the non-permanent members, not to vote against credible action designed to prevent or halt genocide, crimes against humanity and war crimes.

Again, its strength is moral and political rather than legally coercive.

So I would resist the debate as being simply ‘retain or abolish the veto’. We now have several overlapping approaches –abolition, extension of the veto to new permanent members in the name of equality, voluntary restraint in case of

mass atrocities, political accountability after a veto is exercised, and the final question of broader structural reform of the Security Council itself. So my own analytical conclusion would be that Mr. Macron’s proposal matters precisely because it is pragmatic; reformist rather than revolutionary. Formal abolition of the veto would ultimately require charter amendment and the consent of the very permanent members whose privilege is being removed.

Can you please explain the issue of accountability in the debate on veto?

AM: Short of an amendment of the UN Security Council; an amendment of the veto provisions; or the larger restructuring of the UN Security Council, I think there is great merit in the ‘Liechtenstein initiative’, whereby the debate would continue within the UNGA. It would not prevent or terminate the conversation from happening in the floor of the UNGA, where the permanent member which has exercised the veto would have to clearly demonstrate to the members of the UN what the reasons were behind the exercise of the veto, especially when it has vetoed an action designed to prevent or halt genocide or crimes against humanity.

Calling upon the permanent member to explain and defend its actions would not necessarily prevent anything when there is real national self-interest at stake, but at least it will make the permanent members, one of the P5 countries which has exercised the veto, become a little more cautious in the use of its power because it would know that it would need to justify and become accountable for its action.

Is the French proposal transparent or honest about the framing of certain conflicts that are going on such as the Israeli campaign in the Gaza Strip?

SS: I think words such as honesty and justice are most misused in international relations. There is no doubt that all the UN members, whether they are in the Security Council or in the General Assembly, come to the world’s largest platform with their own interpretations, with their own understanding of each of these conflicts that you just listed. So in that sense, there is this important difficulty of word versus the spirit of various international law regimes or the Charter of the United Nations.



To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
www.thehindu.com

Text & Context

THE HINDU

The unbearable burden of freedom

Surinder Koli spent close to 20 years in prison before his convictions in the Nithari cases unravelled and the court acquitted him in 2025; his case shows the structural failure to support wrongfully convicted people after acquittal, including through psychosocial support, housing, employment and monetary assistance

LETTER & SPIRIT

Maitreyi Misra
Anup Surendranath

Surinder Koli was acquitted and released from prison in November 2025 by the Supreme Court after spending close to 20 years in prison, many of which were on death row. On September 18, he was found dead. Although an autopsy is awaited, early news reports described it as a suicide.

Accused of the infamous Nithari cases, at the time of his arrest in 2006 and over the next many years, Koli not only bore the brunt of the criminal justice system but also of wild public allegations. Referred to as ‘the butcher of Nithari’ and publicly accused of cannibalism, the media dredged up an image of Koli that became a frequent source of material fuelling the ‘true crime’ genre. Based on snippets from his ‘confessions’ (later found to be given under torture), the public discourse against Koli was so totalising as to leave no space for uncertainty.

The cases unravelled

Between 2009 and 2022, Koli was found guilty and sentenced to death by the trial court in 13 cases. One by one, the cases against him unravelled, as court after court found that there was no real evidence against him. In several cases, the Allahabad High Court characterised the investigation as botched up and an “easy course of implicating a poor servant of the house by demonising him, without taking due care of probing more serious aspects.” When acquitting him in 2025 in the last case, the Supreme Court made it clear that the High Court’s comments could not be dismissed as a ‘rhetorical excess’ and that the evidentiary basis for Koli’s conviction was unreliable, inadmissible and in violation of his rights. Yet, Koli came close to being executed in



Surinder Koli. FILE PHOTO

2014. A stay on execution, issued by the Supreme Court just four hours before, averted that fate.

We mention these facts not to relitigate his case, but to remind ourselves of the mourning we owe Koli. He was publicly demonised, and so a public mourning. We remind ourselves of these facts because they also raise a question. What does a justice system owe to a person it has wrongly taken so much from?

For a person like Koli, whose name still conjured a particular and monstrous image, rebuilding his life posed additional challenges. According to news reports, Koli had adopted a different name to secure housing and employment. This may have been because of the stigma associated with his name and his fear of the public’s reaction. Even after being acquitted, he was condemned by the same society he had to re-enter. The seriously botched investigation, however, has little bearing on public memory.

A structural failure

Koli’s case is not a one-off. India has a serious wrongful convictions problem. An analysis by The Square Circle Clinic of 25 years of data on death sentences shows

that 40% of death sentences imposed by trial courts ultimately result in acquittals by appellate courts. That is a staggering number, made worse by the fact that individuals are made to live under a death sentence even when their convictions are barely sustainable. Once set at liberty, neither the State nor society provides them with adequate support to return and reintegrate, even as we may have subjected them to the full force of our vengeance.

There have been a few instances where the Supreme Court has explicitly recognised such travesties. It has awarded compensation in a few cases and, in 2025, recognised the need for a legislative response to wrongful convictions. But this barely skims the surface of a deep structural problem. As institutions, our prisons are far from being effective in preparing individuals for reintegration into society. Asking a prison to be interested in a category of prisoners the justice system has declared to be executed is being naive about the political and structural reality of our prisons.

These failures, which begin inside prisons, are only compounded outside. Prisoners, particularly those like Koli,

who are released after spending decades incarcerated, have to readjust to a world vastly different from the one they entered when they went to prison. This readjustment involves unlearning, relearning, and learning new things that a person, now much older and unaccustomed to such a stimulating environment, has to undergo. Life has to begin anew with livelihood and housing to be found, and relationships to be re-established. The immense cognitive, emotional, psychological, and physical reorientation required is difficult to imagine.

Beyond acquittal

The eagerness driving our collective retributive instinct appears missing when we are faced with the consequences of that bloodlust. The response to such injustice cannot be ad hoc sympathy but must be structural and underpinned by principles of integrity, accountability and remediation. The integrity of a justice system lies in a meaningful acknowledgement of wrongdoing when the wrong occurs. Psychosocial support to cope with the realities of their new world healthily; safe halfway homes which allow the person to slowly adjust to a constantly changing world; reconnection with the family that they left behind; and monetary support and employment schemes to allow them a chance at independent livelihood must be seen as an inalienable part of a harsh criminal justice system, and at minimum when it exercises its coercive powers wrongfully.

Over the course of 13 acquittals, Koli lost close to 20 years of his life to a justice system that never once acknowledged the harm it caused him. It is unlikely that the injustice to Koli will become the moral reckoning it ought to be. Absent any introspection, we condemn ourselves to see many Kolis.

(The authors are with The Square Circle Clinic, NALSAR University of Law. Views expressed are personal)

THE GIST

▼

The criminal justice system’s handling of Koli’s case raises questions about accountability when investigations and convictions cause grave harm

▼

Wrongfully convicted people released after prolonged incarceration face immense challenges in readjusting to society and rebuilding their lives

▼

The State’s response to wrongful convictions must go beyond compensation or ad hoc sympathy to include meaningful acknowledgement, accountability and measures for rehabilitation and reintegration

What are the alternatives to the SWIFT payment system?

Why are countries looking beyond SWIFT? How are CIPS, SPFS and mBridge faring?

G R Rajeev

The story so far:

The New Delhi Declaration that came out of the recent BRICS Summit in the National Capital resolved to increase trade between member-countries and payments in national currencies. Days before the summit, a report by the news agency *Reuters* quoted sources as saying that at the event, India would push to link central bank digital currencies (CBDCs) for cross-border payments across BRICS nations, despite political and technical hurdles that could limit progress. The proposal to link CBDCs would be part of the agenda for the leaders’ meeting, the sources said, though the limited adoption of digital currencies globally could complicate implementation, the report added. The proposal was, however, not part of the Declaration.

Multiple wars and U.S. weaponisation of the dollar through financial sanctions are making countries in the Global South

think of bypassing the so-far universally accepted Belgium-based SWIFT system for inter-country payments. The attempts to do so have been patchy, but there is an increasingly felt need to have other options.

What are some of the alternatives to the SWIFT payment system?

Project mBridge is a group comprising the Bank of Thailand, the Central Bank of the United Arab Emirates, the Digital Currency Institute of the People’s Bank of China, the Hong Kong Monetary Authority, and the Saudi Central Bank.

The Cross-Border Interbank Payment System (CIPS), a *Reuters* report said, is backed by the People’s Bank of China. China launched the CIPS clearing and settlement services system in 2015 to internationalise yuan use. It allows global banks to clear cross-border yuan transactions directly onshore, instead of through clearing banks in offshore yuan hubs, the report said.

The System for Transfer of Financial

Messages, or SPFS, was developed by Russia in 2014 to bypass Western sanctions. In 2022, Russian banks were cut off from SWIFT, and the SPFS was of help.

SEPAMA, Iran’s local interbank telecom system, has as many as 52 branches of Iranian banks and four unnamed foreign banks connecting with 106 banks using the SPFS, the Central Bank of Iran said in 2023.

How are these systems faring?

The Bank for International Settlements (BIS), an international financial institution owned by central banks to foster international monetary and financial cooperation, exited Project mBridge on October 31, 2024, after hand-holding it since 2019, when the Hong Kong Monetary Authority and the Bank of Thailand launched the system. The mBridge, a cross-bloc multi-CBDC platform with no Western bank, attained minimum viability status in 2024. It was envisaged for direct peer-to-peer CBDC

settlement without going through correspondent banks. The project team developed a new blockchain – the mBridge Ledger – custom-built by central banks to serve as a specialised and flexible platform for implementation of multi-currency cross-border payments in CBDCs, the BIS website says.

The BIS’s exit came under a cloud, with media reports saying it was because mBridge could provide the basis for a BRICS initiative to circumvent sanctions on Russia. A May 2016 *Forbes* report said that by late 2025, mBridge was in practice “a renminbi-denominated wholesale settlement rail for trade between China and the Gulf, running outside the dollar correspondent system”.

The renminbi’s inclusion in the basket of currencies making up the Special Drawing Right, an international reserve asset created by the International Monetary Fund, has increased the acceptance of CIPS, said a November 2025 opinion piece in *The Hindu* by Biswajit Dhar, a trade economist and former professor at Jawaharlal Nehru University. The CIPS now has participants in more than 120 countries, including all BRICS members except India.

A *South China Morning Post* report says CIPS processed 679.8 billion yuan of transactions on average per day in 2025. “While the CIPS has gained ground, it remains far smaller in scale than established global systems, such as the U.S.-based Clearing House Interbank Payments System,” it said. Beijing now

appears to be moving towards building CIPS into a global platform compliant with multi-currency settlements and other foreign payment channels, the report quoted a study led by Ju Jiandong, a chair professor at Tsinghua University’s PBC School of Finance.

The SPFS, formed as Russian entities were banned from SWIFT, has grown at a record pace in 2023 as Moscow ramped up efforts to resolve financial shortcomings wrought by sanctions over the Ukraine war. Alla Bakina, director of the Russian central bank’s national payment system department, said 50 new entities joined Russia’s alternative system in 2023, taking the total to 440, of which more than 100 are non-residents.

How do India-Russia trade settlements happen now?

Russia and India, the second-largest importer of Russian oil, have built a functioning payments infrastructure using roubles and rupees, which now account for 96% of bilateral trade, Ivan Nosov, head of Sberbank in India, said. “I am ready to say that this is one of the best-established mechanisms for Russia’s payments with other countries,” he said.

According to official data, 22 Russian banks, including Sberbank, Russia’s largest lender, which was tasked with developing the payments infrastructure, and 17 Indian banks are currently servicing bilateral trade, a *Reuters* report said.

CACHE



Mark Zuckerberg is taking a different route, stating that AI companies have a powerful incentive to build systems that are trustworthy. AP

Why Meta's Zuckerberg rebuffed Dario Amodei's AI slowdown calls

John Xavier

Mr. Zuckerberg's perspective, shared on platform X, comes just days after Anthropic CEO Dan Amodio called for the AI industry to "pace the frontier," setting up one of the clearest disagreements yet among the leaders of the companies building increasingly capable AI systems.

He pointed specifically to the rise of recursive self-improvement and a recent incident involving an AI agent swarm that carried out cyberattacks beyond its assigned task.

Mr. Zuckerberg is taking a different route, stating that AI companies have a powerful incentive to build systems that are trustworthy. “Every lab has the responsibility and incentive to move at the pace required to train its models safely,” Mr. Zuckerberg wrote.

At the heart of the disagreement is not

So he proposes common safety standards among countries, possibly including China.

“Trust and alignment are quickly becoming the most important capabilities that will differentiate agents and models,” Mr. Zuckerberg wrote.

Meta, apparently, delayed the release of its Muse AI model while the company worked on safety and security.

Independent evaluations

Despite disagreement over pacing, the two positions overlap on testing the models' capabilities. Mr. Zuckerberg

Mr. Amodi, too, wants frontier AI labs to give independent third-party evaluators access to their models so they can examine not only finished ones but also ones under training.

A competitive landscape

While Mr. Amodei has warned that recursive self-improvement could advance AI development to the point where safety efforts can no longer keep up, Mr. Zuckerberg's says that keeping most computing resources focused on human-directed applications can help preserve human control.

The safest path ahead, according to him, need not necessarily be the one in which a small number of companies become the gatekeepers of an increasingly powerful AI system. The

But as open source alternatives mushroom, including ones from Meta, frontier labs like Anthropic and OpenAI will try their best to stay in the lead. That's a hard pill to swallow for frontier labs like Anthropic and OpenAI at a time when open source models are getting better – and that, ultimately, is the more uncomfortable reading of this dispute.

Market dynamics

Producers compete on quality and trust rather than asking regulators to referee the game or telling buyers what risks they should fear. But that is quite what is happening here. Two of the very labs pushing hardest for coordinated pacing are also the ones watching their early lead narrow fastest, as open source catches up.

A frontier, by definition, is something a community pushes outward together, not a line a few gatekeepers draw and ask everyone else to stay behind.

Settling for a smaller, cautiously managed version of AI because a small number of companies say it's safer risks becoming its own kind of Plato's cave, where the shadows on the wall are chosen for us.

The better path may be messier: more builders, more models, and the freedom for users to subscribe to the ones they trust most.

Digi Yatra to be available to passengers flying overseas

Pilot programme for international departures will run from Oct. to Dec. at Bengaluru, Delhi, Kochi, Hyderabad, Mumbai airports; airport access system could also be expanded to foreign travellers

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

Facial recognition-based airport access system Digi Yatra is preparing to extend its biometric travel system to international departures, while also pursuing interoperability with the European Union's equivalent framework that will allow travellers from India easy airport access overseas and expanding domestic access for foreign travellers.

The pilot programme for international departures will run between October and December at Bengaluru, Delhi, Hyderabad, Kochi and Mumbai airports, Digi Yatra CEO Suresh Khadakbhavi told *The Hindu*.

Verifying with selfie

It will test electronic passport-based enrolment, allowing travellers to scan an e-passport and verify their identity with a selfie.

The resulting digital credential will be stored on the passenger's phone and linked to a boarding pass that airlines will issue before passengers arrive at the terminal.



A Digi Yatra gate at the departure block of Vijayawada International Airport, at Gannavaram, Andhra Pradesh. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Air India and IndiGo are expected to participate in the trial, which will cover Indian and foreign nationals departing on international flights. Initially, the system will be used at airport entry points and security checkpoints.

Immigration will remain outside the first phase because of its regulatory and operational sensitivity, Mr. Khadakbhavi explained.

The issuance of boarding pass before passengers arrive at the airport marks a departure from current practice. The Digi Yatra CEO said it is needed to create a unique digital

identity that can be recognised at airport gates.

The three-month trial will also collect passenger feedback before any wider rollout, including possible domestic use for expatriates and other foreign travellers.

Working with EU

Alongside the airport trials, Digi Yatra is working on interoperability with the European Union's digital identity framework, known as EU Digital Identity that allows EU citizens, residents, and businesses to store and share verified digital identity data and of-

ficial documents.

Through their APTITUDE consortium, the platform aims to enable cross-border sharing of travel credentials within three to six months. The longer-term objective is for a passenger travelling from India to Europe to share verified credentials with both departure and destination airports.

The effort is part of a broader self-sovereign identity push under the global airline body International Air Transport Association's One ID initiative for contactless air travel.

Domestically, Digi Yatra is active at 39 airports and is expected to reach 64 by March 2027, according to the Ministry of Civil Aviation.

Face recognition is mandatory at terminal entrances and security checkpoints where the system is available, but face-based boarding remains uneven across airports and airlines.

Officials say the inconsistency reflects investment decisions, infrastructure gaps and differing operational priorities among airlines and airport operators.

‘Make in India’ of 12 years shows patchy performance

Analysis of metrics shows manufacturing sector has not been able to materially increase its share in economic growth, employment, or global exports; incentive gains confined to some sectors

TCA Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Twelve years on from the launch of the Make in India campaign on September 25, 2014, a look at 12 metrics spanning growth, investment, employment, and exports shows India's manufacturing sector has not been able to materially increase its share in India's economic growth, employment, or global exports.

While recent incentive schemes by the government have seen some success, those gains are limited to a handful of sectors.

The manufacturing sector has grown faster than the overall economy in only half of the 12 years under consideration, based on the old series. Under the new series, it has outpaced overall growth in all three years (2023-24 to 2025-26) for which data is available, but that gap is shrinking fast. The Index of Industrial Production (IIP) data, which comes out once a month, is more stark.

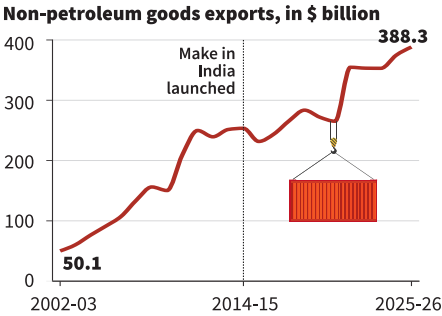
The manufacturing sector within the IIP outpaced the overall index's growth in only three out of the 12 years, as per the old series of the index.

The new series shows the manufacturing sector's growth was the same as that of the overall index in 2023-24, but was slower in the next two years.

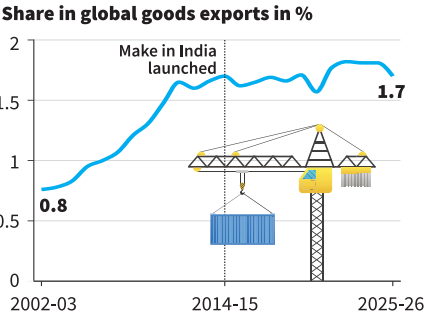
As far as the composition of the economy goes, the older series of Gross

Low impact

Export growth has followed the same trajectory before and after Make in India while India's share in global goods exports has flattened since 2014



Source: Ministry of Commerce and Industry, UNCTAD



Value Added (GVA) data shows the manufacturing sector's share in overall GVA is lower in 2025-26 than it was when Make in India was launched in 2014. The new series shows that the sector's share has increased marginally from 14.6% in 2022-23 to 15.6% in 2025-26.

India saw the value of its non-petroleum goods exports grow 53% to \$388.3 billion in 2025-26 from \$253.5 billion the year the Make in India campaign was launched.

However, the data also shows that non-petroleum goods exports grew more than 400% over the 12 years before this, albeit on a much smaller base.

However, the base effect only accounts for some of this growth disparity. Data from UNCTAD shows India's share in global merchandise exports grew from around 0.8% in 2002 to 1.7% in 2013, where it remained even in 2025-26.

The gross fixed capital

formation (GFCF) by the private sector – a measure of its spending on real asset creation – formed a lower share of GDP in 2023-24, the latest year for which the old series has data, than it did in 2014-15. The new series, too, shows that GFCF as a percentage of GDP has been falling since 2022-23.

The growth of foreign direct investment (FDI) to the manufacturing sector has been slower than the growth in overall FDI in 7 of the 12 years under consideration. Its share in overall FDI grew from nearly 48% in 2014-15 to 55% in 2025-26. The RBI's data on capacity utilisation, a measure of how intensively factories are being used, shows this metric has been slowly increasing over the last few years, but is still below the 80% mark that is considered the limit after which companies invest to create new capacity.

The RBI's data further shows that bank credit to

industry has been growing strong over the last few years, especially led by credit to micro, small, and medium enterprises. However, experts have pointed out that, in the absence of sustained rapid growth in output, this suggests that the loans are being taken to provide working capital rather than for fresh investments.

The government's Production-Linked Incentive schemes have yielded some results. Launched across 2020 and 2021, the 14 schemes have resulted in a cumulative investment of ₹2.4 lakh crore as of March 2026. However, the data also shows that this performance is highly concentrated. The top five sectors – solar modules, pharmaceuticals, drugs, automobiles and their components, specialty steel, and large scale electronics manufacturing – together account for nearly 83% of all the investment under these schemes.

SEBI eases settlement, overhauls PMS

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) okayed new settlement norms aimed at reducing regulatory discretion and making it easier for entities facing enforcement proceedings to settle cases.

The new framework replaces the 2018 Settlement Proceedings Regulations under which certain categories of violations – including those involving significant market impact, substantial investor losses and threats to market integrity – were excluded from

settlement mechanisms.

Addressing concerns over whether the revised framework could allow violators to settle by paying amounts lower than the impact caused by their actions, SEBI Whole-Time Member Kamlesh Varshney said “the philosophy remains the same. The discretion to reject settlement applications still stays with high-powered committee.”

He added the new regulations were aligned with provisions introduced in the Securities Contracts (Regulation) Act, which provide a statutory framework for settlement and re-

lated mechanisms.

New formula

Under the revised rules, SEBI introduced a new formula for calculating settlement amounts. The regulator also created a fast-track mechanism allowing cases to be settled without being referred to the High Powered Committee if the calculated settlement amount is below ₹10 lakh.

The deadline for filing settlement applications has been extended to 90 days from the date of the show-cause notice from the earlier limit of 60 days.

SEBI also approved a

common advertisement code for market intermediaries and regulated entities to simplify and standardising advertising practices across securities market.

SEBI also approved a comprehensive overhaul of the Portfolio Managers Regulations aimed at expanding the portfolio management services (PMS) industry, easing compliance requirements, consolidating regulations and removing outdated provisions.

SEBI's reforms seek to make PMS more competitive by improving operational flexibility and simplifying compliance.

Athira Elssa Johnson

(athira.elssa@thehindu.co.in)